

over the years about persuasive writing. I've used that knowledge in my personal life on many occasions, but the place where it's really paid off is in letters and emails to customer service departments. I've put together a little guide for writing a letter of complaint that will hopefully get you further along than a typical rant and rave.

I should point out that this is advice only for those involved in the most minor of problems. If you get rear-ended by a bus and get hospitalized, you'll need much more than a letter of complaint. But, if you get a bad attitude from a store clerk, this may help you get something other than a snotty reply, or in most cases no reply at all, from the customer service rep.

First up, do you have a genuine complaint?

Silly question, right? But I've talked to many customer service reps in my time, and some of the things they get screamed at for are ridiculous. It's not the company's fault that you ordered a car with cruise control and expected it to be autopilot (that's a real one by the way . . . the mind boggles). Are you ticked off for a genuine reason, or do you just want to lash out because you made a bad purchase? If you feel

you have a genuine, realistic gripe, it's time to take action.

What do you want out of the complaint?

Be reasonable. A bad attitude from a grocery clerk is not going to get you a year of free groceries. A stale bag of chips will not get you a lifetime supply of your favorite snack. Ask for something equal to your disappointment. A bad experience in a restaurant equates to a free meal next time, so try for that. A poor product deserves a refund or replacement. I recently had very, very poor service at a gas station. I wrote and explained what happened, politely, and asked what the company would be willing to do to help restore my faith in their company. I received two gas certificates in the mail a few days later, and I'm happy to go back and try them again.

You catch more flies with sugar than vinegar

Not that I'm calling CSRs flies; that's just an old saying that illustrates a point. If you start spitting venom in your complaint letter, all you're doing is letting that company know that you're irate and probably a lost cause. It's far better to be a loyal, disappointed customer who really wants their faith